battles on these laws turn, from a political standpoint, the BJP's positioning on the issue has been unambiguous.

Even as the party sharpened its positioning on minorities and the minority question after 2014, this identity-based ideological positioning has not been the only reason for its electoral victories. Chapter 3 has shown how, from 2013, the BJP drastically changed its caste representation at all levels of the party: district-level presidents, state officer-bearers, state ministers, Lok Sabha candidates and Vidhan Sabha candidates. It pivoted towards OBCs, who became the single largest caste category that the party put up at all levels. OBCs and SCs together account for 45–55 per cent of BJP representatives at all the levels we studied under the Mehta–Singh Social Index. This new data showed a decline in upper castes and a major rise in representation of castes lower down the social order. By sharing power with these castes at all levels of the party, the BJP became more socially inclusive, leaving aside Muslims.

The new data provided in Part I of this book call for a fundamental rethink of older models of studying the BJP, which continue to frame it essentially as an upper-caste party. That BJP is long gone. The new BJP is differently oriented caste organism altogether. It also created a new model of political mobilisation around labharthees, in a way that has not been done in north India before, as Chapter 4 shows. This has similarities to the practice of Dravidian parties who have long used such modes of personal-welfare-based politics. Together, the resetting of the caste matrix, welfare politics and Hindutva created a new BJP model of politics. It turned the party into a party of the poor and transformed it into the dominant pole of politics in rural India, the default party of the village.